



INTEGRITY RECORDS

WHAT YOU NEED TO UNDERSTAND BEFORE SIGNING A MUSIC CONTRACT

A Free Preview

3 sections from the Complete Guide

"The simple believe anything, but the prudent give thought to their steps."

PROVERBS 14:15

SECTION ONE

Why This Guide Exists

"The simple believe anything, but the prudent give thought to their steps."

PROVERBS 14:15

Every year, gifted artists sign away rights to their own music without fully understanding what they're agreeing to. Not because they're careless, but because record contracts are written in dense legal language designed to be skimmed, not studied. This guide exists to slow you down long enough to actually read the fine print, ask the right questions, and walk into any negotiation with your eyes open.

This isn't about distrust of every label or manager. Most are honest. But the artists who protect themselves best are the ones who understood their contracts before they signed them, not after.

How to Use This Guide

This free preview includes the first three sections of the Complete Guide, so you can see exactly how it works before deciding whether the full edition is right for you.

SECTION TWO

Master Rights vs. Publishing Rights

"Where there is no counsel, the people fall; but in the multitude of counselors there is safety."

PROVERBS 11:14

These are two separate ownership streams, and contracts often blur them on purpose.

Master rights cover the actual recording — the specific audio file. Whoever owns the master controls how that recording is licensed, sold, and used forever. If a movie wants to use your song, they need a master license from whoever owns that master — often the label, not you.

Publishing rights cover the underlying composition — the melody and lyrics — separate from any one recording of it. This matters because someone else can record a cover of your song, and the publishing owner still gets paid on that version too, even if they never touch the master recording.

A contract can quietly ask for both in the same paragraph. Always know which one (or both) you're being asked to sign away, and for how long.

EXAMPLE

An artist signs a deal believing they're only giving up rights to the recording. Buried in the publishing section, however, is a clause assigning 50% of the song's publishing to the label's affiliated publishing arm — meaning the label now earns money any time the song is played on the radio, streamed, or synced to a TV show, on top of whatever the master deal already pays them.

SECTION THREE

Royalty Splits: What's Fair, What's Not

Royalty percentages vary widely, and there's no single 'correct' number — but there are norms worth knowing so you can recognize when an offer is far outside them.

- Major label, new artist: 12% – 20%
- Independent label: 20% – 50%
- Distribution deal (no label): 70% – 100%

These are general ranges, not guarantees — every deal is different. The point isn't to memorize numbers, but to notice when an offer sits far below industry norms without a clear reason why.

Gross vs. Net: The Number Behind the Number

A royalty percentage means very little on its own — what matters is what it's calculated from. A 20% royalty on gross revenue is very different from a 20% royalty on net revenue after the label deducts distribution fees, manufacturing costs, and 'breakage' allowances that may not even apply in a streaming-only world.

Always ask: *Is this percentage calculated from gross receipts, or net receipts after deductions — and if net, which deductions specifically?*

IT'S FREE

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The first 3 sections of the guide, free — no cost, no card required:

- Why This Guide Exists
- Master Rights vs. Publishing Rights
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*Want the rest? The Complete Guide goes nine sections further —
available after you get your free preview.*

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